By night they took their near and dear
And set off on the road to Iran . . .

Meanwhile the heart of Shah Shuja rejoiced to see the devilish Haji
And became free from any fear of the enemy

He showered upon Haji the Sinistrous so many riches
It seemed as if he was stoning him with gold.[51]

Five days later, on 25 April 1839, Haji Khan was on the left side of Shah Shuja as he rode in triumph through fields of ripe wheat and barley, and the rich belt of walled gardens and orchards that still surround the outskirts of Kandahar. On the way, he received delegation after delegation of townspeople coming out to welcome him. 'The poor crowded around him,' wrote Burnes, 'making offerings of flowers and strewing the road he was to pass with roses. Every person, high and low, strove to see how they could most show their devotion and their delight at the return of a Sadozai to power.'[52] Followed by Burnes and Macnaghten and only a small escort of close supporters, Shah Shuja rode unprotected through the open gates and streets of Kandahar, the city that had successfully defied him only five years earlier.

Kandahar's ancient fortunes had been revived by the Shah's grandfather, Ahmad Shah Abdali. He laid out the new town after the old one had been burned and destroyed by Nadir Shah in 1738, and Abdali had chosen to be buried in a delicate Mughal-inspired tomb in its heart. Shuja's first action was to make his way to the tomb garden, take off his riding boots and enter the dome chamber alone. Having prayed at the grave, and asked for his grandfather's *barakat* [blessing] he then went to the building next door. This was the shrine built by Abdali for Afghanistan's most sacred relic, the woollen *khirqa* or mantle said to have belonged to the Prophet Mohammad. This Shuja took in his hands and hugged to his chest, tears streaming down his face.

Three years earlier Dost Mohammad had come here when he wished to declare a jihad against the Sikhs and receive the title Amir al-Muminin, the Commander of the Faithful. One hundred and fifty years later in 1996, Mullah Omar would come too when he was awarded the same title by the Pashtun 'ulema and here he too would swathe himself in the Prophet's cloak to give him the religious authority to bring all the people of Afghanistan under Taliban control. Now Shuja wrapped himself in the same cloth as a